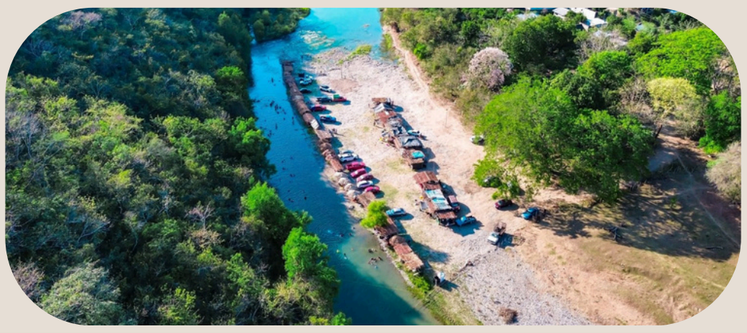
GUARDIANS OF THE CLAY IN CUATZONTITLA: BARRIERS AND COMMERCIALIZATION OPPORTUNITIES IN TRADITIONAL NAHUATL POTTERY

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Context and Justification

In the Nahua community of Cuatzontitla, Tamazunchale, S.L.P. (pop. 256), the artisanal production of clay comales faces a critical risk of extinction due to low economic profitability and the lack of generational replacement.

- External Validity and Global Context: This decline in traditional artisanal knowledge is not an isolated phenomenon; it reflects a well-documented pattern across Mexico and Latin America, where indigenous artisanal micro-economies face severe commercialization barriers, unfair intermediaries, and generational disruption (Fonart, 2020; Moctezuma Yano, 2021; UNESCO, 2021).
- Internal Study Validity: By covering 100% of the active production units (the only three active craftswomen in the locality), this work prioritizes qualitative depth and internal validity over statistical generalization.
- Institutional Background: The project was built upon a prior community engagement of more than five years, establishing an essential bond of trust for the research development.



Research Question and Objective

- Question: What are the socioeconomic barriers and distribution opportunities that influence the commercialization of traditional pottery in the Nahuatl community of Cuatzontitla?
- Objective: To identify socioeconomic constraints and evaluate the feasibility of transitioning toward direct-sales models using low-complexity technologies.







Methodology

- Approach and Design: Qualitative with a descriptive-exploratory scope. Non-probability convenience sampling ($N = 3$ active craftswomen). The unit of analysis was extended to the artisan-family dyad to study the intergenerational transmission of technical and cultural knowledge.
- Fieldwork: 5 community field visits conducted between July and October 2026, following formal authorization from local community authorities.
- Techniques and Instruments: On-site administration of 6 in-depth semi-structured interviews (2 sessions per artisan, lasting 45 to 60 minutes each) conducted directly in their workshops and homes. Data collection was complemented by field notes, photographic records, and audio recordings under informed consent.







Key Findings (Results)

- Logistical Vulnerability: Constant economic losses due to product breakage during transit via public transportation (a process known locally as *ranchado*).
- Commercial Precarity: The physical toll of itinerant vending, combined with exposure to aggressive haggling in marketplaces—which can drive prices down by as much as 60% (from $250 to $100 MXN per *comal*).
- Technological Gap and Family Support: Digital isolation among elderly artisans (aged 70+), mitigated through intergenerational mediation by their children and grandchildren.





Value Proposition and Conclusions

- Alternative Proposal: Willingness was identified toward an order-based sales model using a hybrid, bilingual catalog (Spanish–Nahuatl; digital via WhatsApp and printed for craft fairs), operated through the family network (grandchildren) to bridge the digital divide.
- EAAMO Reflection: Given adverse commercial conditions (breakage, transport strain, and haggling), the analysis demonstrates that the use of low-complexity technologies has the potential to redesign the market mechanism. This approach enables the elimination of information asymmetries, reduces transaction costs, promotes linguistic justice, and guarantees fair trade that dignifies Nahua artisanal work, with operational implementation remaining open for future phases.

References

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